construction.[87] Although placed toward the pinnacle, the verses' rendition in square Kufic allowed for some legibility, at least of certain words, permitting even the less literate among its beholders to recognize the verses.

Indeed, the ideal occasion for commissioning such a monument had presented itself only the year before: in AH 568/1173 CE, a joint push by *both* of Baha' al-Din's sons finally routed the Oghüz encamped at Ghazna, resulting in the Shansabanis' definitive occupation of the city, the crowning of Shihab al-Din as Sultan Mu'izz al-Din, and the establishment of a third Shansabani lineage there – discussed in detail in Chapter 5. Such a significant victory would clearly warrant a monumental commemoration like the splendid *minar*.[88] Moreover, the location of the *minar* at Jam-Firuzkuh, rather than at Ghazna, distinguished it from its architectural predecessors and signified a Shansabani appropriation of the form and its signification. Ultimately, the *minar* plausibly played the role of a victory "trophy": although Shihab al-Din was crowned Sultan Mu'izz al-Din at Ghazna, the *minar*'s location at Jam-Firuzkuh – and its concomitant absence at Ghazna – would serve as a constant (if dyadic) reminder of the familial hierarchy wherein the Firuzkuh Shansabanis sought to be the senior-most lineage of a territorially expanding confederacy.

The analysis of Shah-i Mashhad's extant inscriptions earlier in this chapter revealed not only the significance of the epigraphic programs on Shansabani-patronized architecture, it also underscored these patrons' circumscribed role in determining their content. The distinctive (but complementary) purviews of the Shansabanis as architectural patrons, *vis-à vis* the theological, legal, and literary intelligentsia they also supported, does much to explain the most prominent component of the Jam-Firuzkuh *minar*'s epigraphic program: all of Surat Maryam's (Q. XIX) ninety-nine verses, meandering vertically and delimiting decorative panels all around the *minar*'s lowermost cylindrical shaft (see Appendix, Afghanistan VII: 5).

J. Sourdel-Thomine and F. B. Flood convincingly argued that the Karramiyya still installed at Firuzkuh likely chose this Sura as the *minar*'s epigraphic centerpiece, aiming it at their theological rivals rather than their Shansabani patrons. The Shansabani elites' increasing connections with the more prominent *madhhab*s of Khurasan – as argued throughout this chapter – would have warranted just such a gesture. The Shansabani conquest of *Hanafi* Ghazna, and the towering commemoration of the victory at Firuzkuh, served as the Karramiyya's monumental refutation of the charges of anthropomorphism that the more prominent Sunni *madhhab*s had leveled against them, beginning as early as the eleventh century.[89] The Shansabanis' lack of engagement with the finer points of theology would have made one Sura as acceptable as any other. But for the Karramiyya, such a riposte to their detractors was a matter of political and